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Thousands of UC employees to protest collective bargaining impasse Wednesday

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Author: Andrew Sheeler, The Sacramento Bee | Section: capitol_alert | 910 Words
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Good morning and welcome to the A.M. Alert!

UC CAMPUS PICKET LINE PLANNED FOR WEDNESDAY

Thousands of University of California service and patient care workers are expected to join the picket line to protest what they are calling an impasse in collective bargaining negotiations with the university system.

Protests are expected to take place at UC San Francisco, UC San Diego Medical Center, UC Davis Medical Center, UC Irvine Medical Center and UCLA Reagan Medical Center.

The protest at UC Davis will feature Deputy California Attorney General Maggie Krell, who is running for an Assembly seat, while Assemblyman Isaac Bryan will speak at the UCLA protest.

“The University of California has publicly acknowledged a staff vacancy crisis that ultimately threatens the quality of services it can deliver to its students and patients,” said Michael Avant, president of AFSCME Local 3299, which represents the protesting workers.

“This is a function of UC’s overall failure to compete in the labor market, its failure to pay frontline workers enough to keep pace with rising costs, and its total refusal to commit to the housing affordability solutions workers need in order to live near their jobs,” he said.

Missy Matella, speaking for the UC Office of the President, told The Bee that since January, the university system has met with AFSCME leadership 10 times, each time over the course of a two-day bargaining session, and offered 26 proposals including wage increases, expanded sick leave and new health care credits to offset costs.

“Our wage proposals, introduced in February and again last month, include a 5% across-the-board increase in 2025 and move the minimum wage for AFSCME employees to $25 an hour by July 1, 2025. While all public employers face a difficult budget cycle, UC’s wage package is designed to support our valued employees, putting more money into their pocket so that they use it in a way that best meets their needs,” Matella wrote in an email statement to The Bee.

Matella said that the UC disagrees with AFSCME’s assertion that there is an impasse, “but given our goal of reaching a consensus for their next contract, the university is not disputing the value of a mediator in these negotiations, which is the first step in the impasse process.”

NEWSOM SURVEYS FIRE DAMAGE IN KERN COUNTY

Via Nicole Nixon...

It’s late July and California’s fire season is in full swing.

Gov. Gavin Newsom on Tuesday toured fires burning in Kern and Tulare Counties: the Borel Fire, Trout Fire and Long Fire, which total about 90,000 acres and collectively make up the SQF Lightning Complex.

Over the weekend, Newsom visited the Park Fire near Chico, which is now over 384,000 acres and the sixth-largest wildfire in state history.

“It’s just a reminder of the world we’re living in and the new challenges that we face moving forward,” Newsom said of the longer, more intense fire seasons driven by climate change.

The Borel Fire destroyed the small mining town of Havilah late last week.

“At the end of the day, it’s about people, it’s about history, it’s about memories,” Newsom said, urging people to heed evacuation orders. “You can replace a home. You can’t replace a life.”

The governor thanked President Joe Biden and Texas Gov. Greg Abbott for sending assistance to fight the flames.

Abbott sent more than 100 firefighters and 25 engines to the Golden State to assist with the Park Fire.

White House Press Secretary Karine Jean-Pierre said Biden had been briefed on the fires and that more than 7,000 personnel from the U.S. Forest Service and Department of the Interior have been deployed across the west to fight active wildfires, including more than 620 firefighters in California.

Biden has also approved emergency declarations and additional aid, Newsom said.

“In a voicemail I just got, he said the answer is yes, and I haven’t even asked the question,” he said. “That’s the spirit, the partnership that defines this moment.”

NEWSOM ANNOUNCES NONPROFIT SECURITY GRANT FUNDING

Newsom on Tuesday also announced that the state is speeding up the release of $76 million in grant funding for security for nonprofits, including religious institutions, reproductive health centers and LGBTQ community centers.

“An attack against any community is an attack against our entire state and our values. Every Californian deserves the ability to worship, love, and gather safely, without fear of hate. This new round of funding is aimed at helping high-risk organizations protect themselves against violent attacks and hate crimes,” Newsom said in a statement.

The funding announcement comes amid a surge in antisemitic incidents in California.

“Despite facing significant budget challenges, the California Legislature will continue to stand firm in our commitment to supporting vulnerable communities targeted by hate,” said Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, and Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, in a statement.

Gabriel and Wiener chair their respective houses’ budget committee.

The California State Nonprofit Security Grant Program provides nonprofits with money to pay for security enhancements at their facilities, such as reinforced doors, gates, high-intensity lighting and access control systems.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

“I recently tested positive for COVID. I’m vaccinated and symptoms are not severe. I want to thank Donald Trump for being a bigly believer in COVID vaccines and starting Operation Warp Speed.”

- Rep. Ted Lieu, D-Los Angeles, via X.

Best of The Bee:

Undocumented immigrants in California are paying billions in taxes. Here’s how much, via David Lightman and

Mathew Miranda.Gavin Newsom signals support for bills to crack down on deepfake election content, via Nicole Nixon.

A previous version of this story incorrectly attributed the response from the University of California Office of the President. That response came from Missy Matella.

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